

Snappy Ubuntu ensures Docker container security

Canonical is working on a new tool to ease the process of updating cloud container applications. The tool is called Snappy Ubuntu, which is a version of the Ubuntu Core. Canonical claims that the command line utility that handles package and update management in Snappy Ubuntu is faster than ever.

The main focus of Snappy Ubuntu is to optimise the performance of Dockerised apps. Canonical has built Snappy Ubuntu in a minimalist and secure way. The tool is made for the Docker container applications, so it is important that the Docker host is lean and secure, which Snappy Ubuntu takes care of.

Snappy Ubuntu is designed in such a way that users will be able to validate whether the product that they downloaded has the feature that they are looking for. They can also validate the current state of the disk matching that application. Snappy Ubuntu apps are packaged as 'snaps'.

Snappy Linux can be secured with AppArmor security profiles. AppArmor is a Linux technology that enforces mandatory access controls on system processes and applications. Ubuntu has been including AppArmor in its Linux distribution since the Ubuntu 7.10 Gutsy Gibbon release in 2007.

Canonical has partnered with Microsoft for the distribution of Snappy Ubuntu. The beta version of Snappy is available through Microsoft Azure. The team behind Snappy Ubuntu is really excited about user reviews. The open discussion thread will be initiated on Ubuntu Community by Snappy Ubuntu to reach out to the user database and get responses. Canonical will reveal the future plans and production schedule of Snappy Ubuntu in the coming months.

Version 3.18 of Linux kernel released

Linux kernel ver 3.18 is finally here, though the issue of the nasty lockup is yet to be resolved by developers. It is being reported that Dave Jones, popular Linux kernel hacker, is not far from a solution. This issue had also affected Linux kernel ver 3.17 but not many users suffered from it. That's why Linus Torvalds, the father of Linux, was in no mood to delay Linux 3.18 just because of this single drawback, and gave the release a go-ahead.

Torvalds was also concerned that if the Linux 3.18 release got delayed, then it would affect the schedules of the releases that are to follow, which include the opening of the Linux 3.19 merge window. Subsequent releases would get complicated then, as the holiday season is also nearing. A lot of new features have been included in the latest Linux 3.18 kernel, and excitement about the upcoming Linux 3.19 activities have also started building up.

Linux 3.18 was named the 'Diseased Newt' by Torvalds, who as per tradition, announced the official release on the Indiana kernel mailing list. In his announcement, Torvalds mentioned that he would have loved to announce that all the problems persisting in Linux 3.17 had been resolved but that was not the case.

IITs, IIMs will now offer online courses

Leading institutes of India including the IITs and IIMs are planning to adopt the Massive Open Online Courses (MOOCs) format. Moving ahead on these lines, PM Narendra Modi is planning an ambitious launch of the Swayam Bharat programme. The Indian Institute of Technology-Bombay and the Indian Institute



of Management-Calcutta have already announced MOOCs for students, along with their overseas partners.

IIT Kanpur, on the other hand, is planning to launch its own exclusive platform for MOOCs, named MOOKIT, which might give tough competition to other international

MOOC platforms like edX and Coursera.

Saibal Chattopadhyay, IIM Calcutta's director said, "MOOCs and online delivery is clearly the future." IIT Bombay is initially trying out only two courses in the MOOCs mode, the basic computer programming course for undergraduates and a thermodynamics course. However, the institute has planned many more. Narayan Rangaraj, dean, academic programmes, said, "More are planned. There have been multiple meetings with the HRD ministry and IIT Bombay expects to be a very active partner in the government's initiative."

T V Prabhakar, a professor at IIT Kanpur, said that in addition to MOOKIT, the institute is also working on developing MOOCs across verticals like agriculture and computer science. The institute had recently wrapped up its 'MOOC on MOOCs' programme, in which over 2,300 students participated. The institute is also offering MOOC content on mobiles.

IIM Bangalore is planning to devise a course on the edX platform in 2015. According to its director, Sushil Vachani, the institute is also planning to engage around 15 per cent of its faculty to deliver MOOCs over the next two years.